

late 1700s, it became increasingly common to add some brandy—essentially a young, clear neutral spirit distilled from wine—during fermentation. This stopped the process before all the natural sweetness of the grape juice was converted into alcohol. Since wine was no longer fermenting, it ensured it never spoiled. However, a happy result of that was that you got a sweet, distinct, flavourful wine which became all the rage in England. Since it was being shipped from the city of Porto, it came to be called port wine.

While there are 14 demarcated wine-producing regions in Portugal, the Douro Valley is the only one legally allowed to produce port wine—thanks to the Marquês de Pombal, who demarcated the region in 1756. Think of it a bit like the Champagne region of France.

So, it's not surprising that historically the region has focussed on the production of port; however, over the past century local vineyards have started producing other wines too. It's this expanding offering that led the region to be named European Wine City in 2023.

There are several wine tours from Porto (Portugal's second-largest city) to the Douro Valley. It's around a two-and-a-half-hour drive from the city, and a full-day tour typically includes a visit to a couple of historic quintas (wine estates)—there are over 200 of those—and a cruise on the river.

I visit a small boutique estate called Quinta de Santa Julia from 1596. It produces only 200,000 bottles of wine every year, along with 20,000 bottles of olive oil, which happens to be one of Portugal's largest exports.

Here wine is still produced the traditional way—with grapes being stomped by foot. In fact, I find out that to make the finest port, many vineyards continue to do so.



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Machines break the grape seeds, releasing too many tannins, which makes the port bitter, my guide tells me. On the other hand, soft feet against stone keep the seeds intact. During harvest time (mid-September through early October), the grapes are poured into big granite tubs called lagares. A team of two dozen stompers line up across from each other, put their arms on each other's shoulders, and march, military-style, to crush the grapes. The stomping can last three to four days. In fact, tourists are invited to join in, so if you happen to

visit during the harvest season, do give wine-stomping a chance. But be warned that your legs will turn purple for at least a week!

Another unique feature of the Douro Valley is that there is no artificial irrigation. The valley is spread across 250,000 acres, of which 45,000 acres are vineyards, producing some 80 different types of grapes. While the lion's share of the harvest is set aside for the four different types of port wine—ruby, tawny, white and rosé—grapes are also being used for table wines.

Driving through the region you